Minnesota's New Immigrants: A Content Analysis of the Minneapolis Star Tribune's Coverage of the Minnesota Somali Community

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STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

Minorities and the mainstream media have always been at odds when it comes to the types of coverage these communities receive. The Minnesota Somali community, one of the fastest growing minorities in the state, has always detested the coverage they receive from the state's leading newspaper, the Star Tribune. The community worries that they are portrayed negatively in the paper and their voices are not heard. To better understand their fears and address them, this research looks at the stories that were published in the Star Tribune from 2003-2010. The aim is to shed light on the ways in which the Somali community is portrayed.

BACKGROUND

Minnesota is home to the largest Somali community in the United States. The Somali community often receives extensive news coverage. However, not many studies about the community and its media coverage have been done. In 2008, Chelsey Perkins, an undergraduate student did the first study that looked at coverage of the Somali community in the Star Tribune. Our study replicates and extends Perkins' study in order to see whether or not the same negative patterns found in her study still persist.

METHOD

Chelsey Perkins' developed a coding system that she used in her 2008 study. This study required the use of Perkins' coding system.

To attain the stories for the content analysis, we used the LexisNexis Academic database . We chose the Minneapolis Star Tribune as the source and the search term "Somali*" and function "Headline" in order to gather the content to analyze. The study analyzed stories from 01/01/2003-05/01/2010.

We looked at the ethnicity, religion and jobs of the first three sources. We also coded the topics of stories (e.g. immigration, crime, culture, community). The study evaluated whether or not the stories used keywords like terrorism, Islam and refugee. We assessed the overall tone of the stories; were they positive or negative toward Somalis/Muslims.

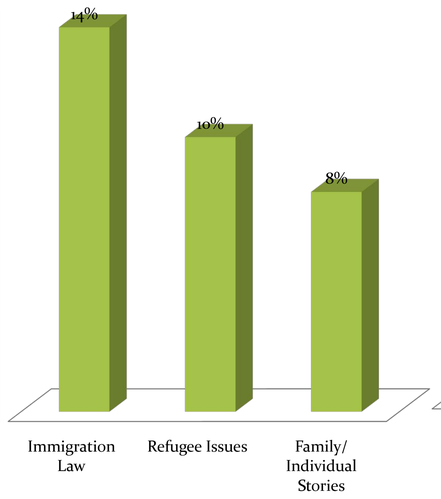
RESULTS

Table 1 : Location of the stories

Front Page (A1)	37 (20)
Front Section	21 (11)
Metro – front (B1)	41 (22)
Metro – inside	65 (35)
Sports – front	1 (.5)
Sports – inside	1 (.5)
Business – front	4 (2)
Business – inside	1 (.5)
Source – front	3 (2)
Source – inside	0 (0)
Other (inside)	10 (5)

Note: right column contains number of stories (%)

Graph 1:: Immigration Discussed



Graph 2: Crime Discussed

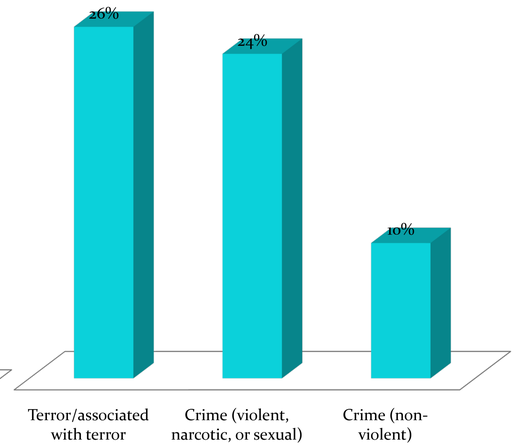


Table 4: Overall Themes of Stories

Theme/Content Emphasized	
Humanize, personalize Somalis/Somali-Americans	20 (11)
Talk about Somali/Somali-Americans using statistics/information from few Somali sources or non-Somali sources	144 (78)
Talk about Muslim Somalis/Somali-Americans in relation to terrorists, terrorism, etc	20 (11)
Other	0
Total	184

Note: right column contains number of stories (%)

Table 2: Sources quoted in the stories

	Source 1	Source 2	Source 3
U.S. – non-Somali	78 (42)	75 (41)	54 (29)
Somali/Somali-American	101 (55)	77(42)	59 (32)
Other African nations	0	0	0
European/Asian/Australian/South American	0	0	0
Other	1 (.5)	2 (1)	2 (1)
Unknown*	4 (2)	30 (16)	70 (38)
Total	184	184	184

Note: right column contains number of stories (%) *unknown includes stories with no source

Graph 3: Community Discussed

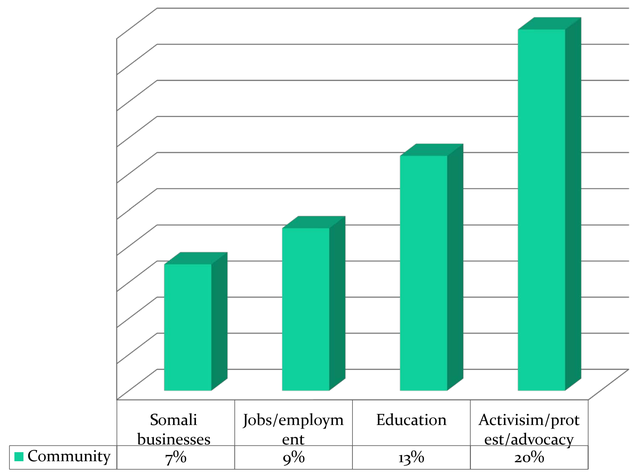
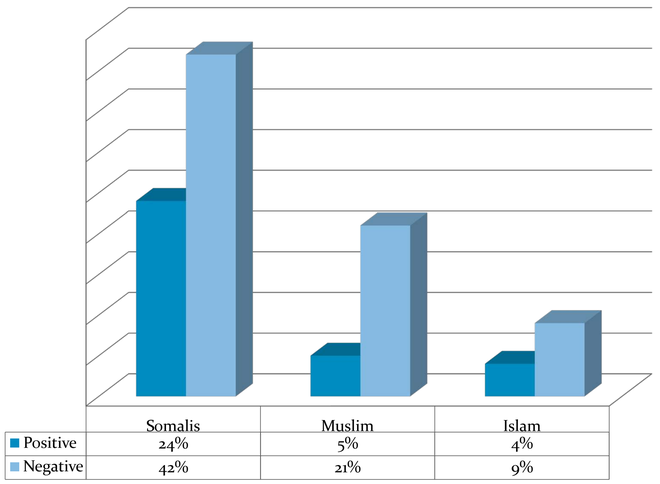


Table 3: Jobs/Roles of sources

	Job/Roles
Somali community organization	84
Somali community members	63
federal government official (non-Somali)	34
state or local government official (non-Somali)	22
police official (non-Somali)	21
lawyer*	41
Other (Somalis and non-Somali)	66

Note: right column contains number of stories (%)
* Only 3 Lawyer were identified Somali

Graph 4: Overall tone of the stories



DISCUSSION

Our study found that...

- Compared to Perkins' study of 1993-2006, more Somali sources were quoted. However, they were often the same people from a small number of organizations. One man was quoted 24% of the Somali sources. Non-Somalis in comparison were more likely to be government official or other authority figures.
- We found that the stories did not greatly reflect the diversity or diversity of opinions within the Somali community.
- Considerable numbers of the stories consist of issues relating to immigration and/or crime.
- A large number of the stories referenced to terrorism and portrayed Somali/Muslims negatively.
- However, there was no evidence to support the statement that stories will be "buried" within the paper.
- We found that 46 percent were on the front page.

CONCLUSION & RECOMMENDATION

Several of our hypothesis were found to be correct. These findings show the need to further the discourse regarding the coverage immigrant communities like the Somali community receives in the media. Due to the limited number of studies done on this topic, more research is needed to advance the understanding media's coverage of this community.